

Government Leverages Open Source to Build DigiLocker for Indian Citizens



DigiLocker is an initiative by the government to offer Indian citizens a free platform to store and access important documents. The platform uses several open source technologies to deliver a mass solution and contributes back to the ever-growing community.

As the world is moving towards the concept of digital government and e-governance, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has sketched out his vision for the Digital India model. This envisages transforming India into a digitally empowered society. DigiLocker is perhaps the government's largest project based on open source technologies. It has already attracted over two million Indians who have uploaded their documents on the dedicated cloud storage space that is available for free.

"DigiLocker is targeted at paperless governance. It is a platform to issue and verify certificates and documents digitally, and thus eliminate the use of physical documents," says Debabrata Nayak, additional director, National e-Governance Division (NeGD).

A small team behind a big project

Nayak is leading an in-house development team of just around 14 people who have developed DigiLocker. The team includes some government personnel as well as individuals from private firms.

"Our technical team is a mix of people with a background in PHP, Java, .NET and Python, and we prefer those with previous experience in open source technologies. We have individuals from various domains such as the government, banking, insurance, services and products," Nayak says.

The team collectively contributed to a robust solution to ultimately enable paperless governance. Unlike a traditional cloud storage solution like Dropbox or Google Drive, DigiLocker comes in two separate parts. One part is designed to store links to documents that are issued to you by the government agencies that have signed up with DigiLocker, while the other can be used to upload any legacy or old documents that you wish to. There is also 1GB of space to store documents on the cloud.

Apart from various multi-skilled engineers, the team at NeGD has Amit Ranjan, who co-founded SlideShare, which was recently acquired by Microsoft-owned LinkedIn. Ranjan brings the spirit of the startup to DigiLocker.

Nayak feels that finding the right talent for open source development is quite easy nowadays but searching for open source contributors is still difficult. "The culture of actively contributing to open source projects has yet to become mainstream in India among the IT community," he explains.

Multiple components under one roof

DigiLocker sports three major components – a repository, an access gateway and cloud-based dedicated personal storage. The repository is used to archive e-documents, whereas the gateway provides a secure mechanism for users to access documents from various online repositories, and the cloud